

hardware would be the road and software, the car. If you have a great OS and the hardware doesn't support it, the OS is a waste. The performance and smoothness of any application depends on the hardware and it's more so for the operating system. If the OS doesn't run well, you can be sure that no application will either. Naturally, hardware requirements and compatibility issues for an OS carry much more weight than they do for any app. Windows 8 has a higher set of hardware requirements compared to Windows 7. Don't worry though; they've not been increased much.

Processor

If your processor can run Windows 7, it can also run Windows 8. The system requirements on the processor side is the same for Windows 8 – 1 GHz of clock speed. But we're talking about one of the most sophisticated and complex electronic units being produced at the moment. Windows 8 has raised the bar in terms of features supported by the processor. It now requires PAE, NX and SSE2.

1. **PAE:** Physical Address Extension is a feature that allows a 32-bit OS to address more than 4 GB of memory installed on the computer. It's a hardware feature and has been there since quite some time now; almost since we entered the new millennium. You shouldn't worry about it. It might however be the case that the BIOS settings on your PC are set to NOT use PAE which you should be able to change.
2. **NX:** NX stands for Never eXecute. This feature disallows the execution of code in the data segment of a program's address space. It ends up providing an elevated application-level security. Intel calls the technology 'XD'. Interestingly, for NX to function, the processor must run in PAE mode.
3. **SSE2:** This technology too has been around since the last decade and is a SIMD (Single Instruction Multiple Data) instruction set which is immensely useful in processing video.

Your processor should have all of the above unless it's more than a decade old.

Memory

It's just as much as it was for Windows 7 – 1 GB. Though Microsoft recommends that you have 4 GB, we've used the OS on as low as 1.5 GB and it works just fine. However, for 64-bit installations, you must have 2 GB of RAM or you would have to live with a lot of lag.